had greater impact had it been said to my face. Matty Prior was accused of ‘backstabbing’ and Andy Flower was unfairly attacked. We faced a modern dilemma: would responding to such unwarranted slurs merely add to the hysteria?

Probably so, but the abuse was so personal, and the situation so tawdry, that the Professional Cricketers’ Association, our union, in conjunction with the ECB, felt impelled to act. An ECB statement referred to ‘a breach of trust and team ethics’. It supported both my captaincy and the culture we were attempting to create. Confidence was also expressed in Prior and Flower.

The over-riding irony was that the three of us had done everything possible to make the relationship work. We had driven the decision to bring Kevin back in 2012, and gave him the chance to extend his international career. That was lost on those swept along by inaccurate perceptions of betrayal. At times, they seemed beyond reason.

The vehemence of such personalized attacks is disturbing, and there would be moments in the months to come when I felt isolated and persecuted, scapegoated by people who gleefully picked at the scab of an ultimately pointless debate. I must admit I didn’t see any evidence of Kevin’s sensitivity to others, which seemed so central to his supporters, but I’m not one for bitterness.

Others in the firing line, principally Andy and Matty, had also done nothing to merit such denigration. Claims of a bullying culture were completely wide of the mark, but as contracted players we were ordered by the ECB not to respond because they didn’t want the situation to be further inflamed. We weren’t allowed to provide context. I am all for keeping a dignified silence, but it was a mess.

Was the atmosphere in the England dressing room uncomfortable at times? You bet. That’s inevitable when you have highly competitive people who don’t conform to the so-called norm striving for the sort of success that’s very public but acutely personal. These were once-in-a-generation players, driven by the intensity of a consciously created climate.

Of course, there was piss-taking, which exists in every dressing room at every level of the game. It’s politically incorrect, most of the time, often childish, but harmless because it is not vindictive or intended to be taken seriously.